SSC MTS 2023 question paper with answers

13 September 2023 · Shift 3

48 questions as the Staff Selection Commission (SSC) printed them · answers from the official key · marking: 3 marks a question; no negative marking in Session-I (Numerical and Mathematical Ability, Reasoning), 1 mark deducted for each wrong answer in Session-II (General Awareness, English).

The other 42 of the paper's 90 questions are not reproduced: they need a figure or are printed as an image, or ask about formatting the source does not keep.

Try every question first: the answer key and the explanations follow the questions. Official answer-key notice: https://web.archive.org/web/20231223070914/https://ssc.nic.in/SSCFileServer/PortalManagement/UploadedFiles/Writeup_MTS2023_22122023.pdf

Numerical and Mathematical Ability 2 questions

Q.5

A shopkeeper bought an oven for ₹25,000 and sold it for ₹29,500. He spent ₹1,500 as overheads. What is his loss or gain percentage (rounded off to the nearest integer)?

(A) Loss by 11%
(B) Gain by 13%
(C) Loss by 13%
(D) Gain by 11%

Q.20

A car covers 60 km at a speed of 84 km/h. If the average speed for the whole journey is 72 km/h, then the speed of the car for the next 60 km of the journey is:

(A) 63 km/h
(B) 68 km/h
(C) 78 km/h
(D) 75 km/h

Reasoning Ability and Problem Solving 1 question

Q.17

Seven people, W, D, J, S, H, G and Y are sitting in a straight line, facing south. G sits second to the left of S. G is the immediate neighbour of D and H. Y sits third to the right of D. Only two people sit to the right of W. Who sits at the extreme right end of the line?

(A) W
(B) Y
(C) J
(D) G

General Awareness 20 questions

Q.1

In which year was the Pradhan Mantri Rojgar Protsahan Yojana (PMRPY) launched?

(A) 2018
(B) 2015
(C) 2016
(D) 2022

Q.2

The film based on which of the following novels by Amrita Pritam won the National Film Award?

(A) Nagmani
(B) Raseedi Ticket
(C) Village No.36
(D) Pinjar

Q.4

Who was the Prime Minster of India when the Fundamental Duties were first incorporated in the Constitution of India?

(A) Jawaharlal Nehru
(B) Indira Gandhi
(C) Atal Bihari Vajpayee
(D) Rajiv Gandhi

Q.5

Who said the following? “Money is what money does.”

(A) Prof. Seligman
(B) Prof. Cole
(C) Prof. Walker
(D) Prof. Robertson

Q.6

Which of the following ports is located in Odisha?

(A) Haldia port
(B) Kandla port
(C) Paradip Port
(D) Tuticorin Port

Q.7

Rohini Bhate, Pandit Munnalal Shukla, Kumudini Lakhia and Uma Sharma are famous exponents of which of the following classical dance forms?

(A) Bharatanatyam
(B) Kathakali
(C) Kathak
(D) Kuchipudi

Q.9

India played the final of ODI Cricket World Cup 2011 against which country?

(A) Australia
(B) Sri Lanka
(C) England
(D) Pakistan

Q.10

Mohiniyattam is a classical dance style belongs to _____.

(A) Kerala
(B) Odisha
(C) Manipur
(D) Tamil Nadu

Q.11

Which of the following is NOT a feature of the Indian political party system?

(A) Lack of effective opposition
(B) Single party system
(C) Multi-party system
(D) Factions and defections

Q.12

Which of the following was the first Satyagraha Movement led by Mahatma Gandhi in British India?

(A) Champaran Satyagraha
(B) Kheda Satyagraha
(C) Rowlatt Satyagraha
(D) Bardoli Satyagraha

Q.14

The fundamental vocabulary of _____ dance constitutes mock combat techniques, stylised gaits of birds and animals and movements modelled on the chores of village housewives and mostly performed by male dancers in Eastern India.

(A) Manipuri
(B) Kathakali
(C) Chhau
(D) Sattariya

Q.15
The Red Fort is located in:

(A) Lucknow
(B) Delhi
(C) Indore
(D) Ahmedabad

Q.16
The Goa government launched a new scheme in November 2022 for which of the following?

(A) Ithihas Darshan
(B) Goa Darshan
(C) Bharat Darshan
(D) Dev Darshan

Q.17
Ruturaj Gaikwad became the first batsman in List-A cricket to hit how many sixes in an over?

(A) 4
(B) 5
(C) 6
(D) 7

Q.19
Camels are found in which type of forests in India from the following?

(A) Montane forests
(B) The thorn forest and scrubs
(C) Mangrove forests
(D) Tropical evergreen forests

Q.20
Under whom among the following British Governor-Generals was the new policy of ‘paramountcy’ initiated in British India by the East India Company?

(A) Lord Hastings
(B) Lord Amherst
(C) Lord Wellesley
(D) Lord Cornwallis

Q.21
Paryushana Parva is a festival of which of the following communities?

(A) Jain
(B) Christian
(C) Parsi
(D) Hindu

Q.22
Who coined the word ‘cell’ in the 1600s, from the Latin word ‘cellula’, meaning ‘small room’?

(A) Louis Pasteur
(B) Robert Hooke
(C) Theodor Schwann
(D) Lynn Margulis

Q.23
Which of the following is a feature of Micro Finance Institutions?

(A) Financial service to government employees
(B) Finance service to Union ministers
(C) Financial service to corporate
(D) Financial service to disadvantaged people

Q.24
Which of the following States became the overall champions in both the men’s and women’s categories in the 2023 Janjatiya Khel Mahotsav?

(A) Chhattisgarh
(B) Karnataka
(C) Jharkhand
(D) Odisha

English Language and Comprehension 25 questions

Q.1

The following sentence has been split into four segments. Identify the segment that contains a grammatical error and select the option which rectifies that error. The space agency wanted / to test with a chimp / before orbiting a astronaut / in a Mercury capsule.

(A) The space agency want
(B) in an Mercury capsule.
(C) before orbiting an astronaut
(D) to test with an chimp

Q.2

Select the most appropriate option that can substitute the underlined segment in the given sentence. They said that “he is not going to call them”.

(A) he shall not call them
(B) he has not gone to call then
(C) they are not going to call them
(D) he was not going to call them

Q.3

Parts of the following sentence have been underlined and given as options. Select the option that contains a misspelt word. For every “endeavour”-whether in the area of “career”, “academics”, music, sports or even in spirituality, it is a long “ardous” journey.

(A) ardous
(B) endeavour
(C) academics
(D) career

Q.4

Select the most appropriate meaning of the underlined idiom. The entrepreneur decided to “throw caution to the wind”.

(A) Take a risk
(B) Take the best option
(C) Think innovatively
(D) In extreme windy conditions

Q.5

Select the most appropriate synonym of the given word. Tedious

(A) Carefree
(B) Hostile
(C) Dynamic
(D) Dreary

Q.6

Select the option that can be used as a one-word substitute for the given group of words. Not fit for eating

(A) Inept
(B) Ineligible
(C) Ineluctable
(D) Inedible

Q.7

The following sentence has been split into four segments. Identify the segment that contains an error. If he had paid / attention to the announcement, / he had not / missed the train.

(A) If he had paid
(B) he had not
(C) attention to the announcement
(D) missed the train

Q.8

Select the most appropriate meaning of the given idiom. Child’s play

(A) In someone’s role
(B) Something very easy
(C) Weakness
(D) Just behaviour

Q.9

Select the option that rectifies the spelling of the underlined word in the given sentence. The tour company has included all the activities that you have requested in your “itenarary”.

(A) itinerarey
(B) itenerarey
(C) itinerary
(D) itenerary

Q.10

Select the most appropriate meaning of the given idiom. Spill the beans

(A) To believe something as it seems
(B) To tell a secret
(C) To do things in a fair way
(D) To cry over what is done

Q.11

Select the most appropriate meaning of the underlined idiom. The mother requested the nurse to “keep an eye on” the baby while she went for tea.

(A) Keep informed
(B) Mistreat
(C) Watch and take care
(D) Watch for the arrival or appearance

Q.12

Select the most appropriate option that can substitute the underlined segment in the given sentence. If you need any help tomorrow, “let him knows.”

(A) let me know
(B) let us known
(C) let him known
(D) let them knew

Q.13

Select the most appropriate option that can substitute the underlined segment in the given sentence. Helena loves to dig and “played in the dirt” like any other child.

(A) playing on dirt
(B) playing with in dirt
(C) plays of dirt
(D) play in the dirt

Q.14

Select the most appropriate option that can substitute the underlined segment in the given sentence. The development of skills can contribute to structural transformation and economic growth “in enhance employability” and labour productivity and helping countries to become more competitive.

(A) about enhancing employability
(B) by enhanced employability
(C) by enhancing employability
(D) for enhanced employability

Q.15

Select the most appropriate option that can substitute the underlined segment in the given sentence. Everyone “likes in watch” a magic show.

(A) likes to watching
(B) like in watching
(C) likes to watch
(D) liked in watch

Q.16

The given sentence contains an error. Select the option that correctly rectifies the error. He is the better-looking hero in the entire film industry.

(A) He is the best-looking hero in the entire film industry.
(B) He is the good-looking hero than the entire film industry.
(C) He is the best-looking hero more than the entire film industry.
(D) He is the good-looking hero in the entire film industry.

Q.17

Select the most appropriate option to fill in the blank. He is first _____ to his job and then to his family.

(A) enabled
(B) committed
(C) confirmed
(D) convinced

Q.18

Select the most appropriate synonym of the given word. Pretend

(A) Feign
(B) Benign
(C) Align
(D) Reign

Q.19

Select the most appropriate ANTONYM of the given word. Align

(A) Position
(B) Disrupt
(C) Centre
(D) Coincide

Q.20

Select the option that rectifies the spelling of the underlined word in the given sentence. One of her colleagues had agreed to act as the “arbitratore” in finalising the contract.

(A) arbitetrator
(B) arbitor
(C) arbitraitor
(D) arbitrator

Q.21

In the following passage, some words have been deleted. Read the passage carefully and select the most appropriate option to fill in each blank. There will only be two types of human beings in the future: the minority having enormous brains and (1)_____ bodies, and the majority with tiny brains and muscular bodies. The size of the average brain will (2)_____ diminish; not because of our innate laziness, but because of our over-concern about our physical appearance. In the old days, most people dreamt of having shelter and a stable food supply. As we no longer struggle for the basic (3)_____, our dreams focus instead on the search for physical beauty, how to obtain and maintain the ‘ideal body shape’ and healthy life the media promotes. Physical beauty will become the main goal of the majority. They’ll do exercises every day, taking (4)_____ to maintain their shape while not noticing that their brains are shrinking. Actually, there is no doubt that they’ll work (5)_____ hard to make their brains smaller.

Select the most appropriate option to fill in blank number 1.

(A) cute
(B) minor
(C) tiny
(D) minute

Q.22

In the following passage, some words have been deleted. Read the passage carefully and select the most appropriate option to fill in each blank. There will only be two types of human beings in the future: the minority having enormous brains and (1)_____ bodies, and the majority with tiny brains and muscular bodies. The size of the average brain will (2)_____ diminish; not because of our innate laziness, but because of our over-concern about our physical appearance. In the old days, most people dreamt of having shelter and a stable food supply. As we no longer struggle for the basic (3)_____, our dreams focus instead on the search for physical beauty, how to obtain and maintain the ‘ideal body shape’ and healthy life the media promotes. Physical beauty will become the main goal of the majority. They’ll do exercises every day, taking (4)_____ to maintain their shape while not noticing that their brains are shrinking. Actually, there is no doubt that they’ll work (5)_____ hard to make their brains smaller.

Select the most appropriate option to fill in blank number 2.

(A) properly
(B) gradually
(C) appropriately
(D) slightly

Q.23

In the following passage, some words have been deleted. Read the passage carefully and select the most appropriate option to fill in each blank. There will only be two types of human beings in the future: the minority having enormous brains and (1)_____ bodies, and the majority with tiny brains and muscular bodies. The size of the average brain will (2)_____ diminish; not because of our innate laziness, but because of our over-concern about our physical appearance. In the old days, most people dreamt of having shelter and a stable food supply. As we no longer struggle for the basic (3)_____, our dreams focus instead on the search for physical beauty, how to obtain and maintain the 'ideal body shape' and healthy life the media promotes. Physical beauty will become the main goal of the majority. They'll do exercises every day, taking (4)_____ to maintain their shape while not noticing that their brains are shrinking. Actually, there is no doubt that they'll work (5)_____ hard to make their brains smaller.

Select the most appropriate option to fill in blank number 3.

(A) necessities
(B) identities
(C) facilities
(D) amenities

Q.24

In the following passage, some words have been deleted. Read the passage carefully and select the most appropriate option to fill in each blank. There will only be two types of human beings in the future: the minority having enormous brains and (1)_____ bodies, and the majority with tiny brains and muscular bodies. The size of the average brain will (2)_____ diminish; not because of our innate laziness, but because of our over-concern about our physical appearance. In the old days, most people dreamt of having shelter and a stable food supply. As we no longer struggle for the basic (3)_____, our dreams focus instead on the search for physical beauty, how to obtain and maintain the 'ideal body shape' and healthy life the media promotes. Physical beauty will become the main goal of the majority. They'll do exercises every day, taking (4)_____ to maintain their shape while not noticing that their brains are shrinking. Actually, there is no doubt that they'll work (5)_____ hard to make their brains smaller.

Select the most appropriate option to fill in blank number 4.

(A) nutrition
(B) nutrients
(C) preservatives
(D) additives

Q.25

In the following passage, some words have been deleted. Read the passage carefully and select the most appropriate option to fill in each blank. There will only be two types of human beings in the future: the minority having enormous brains and (1)_____ bodies, and the majority with tiny brains and muscular bodies. The size of the average brain will (2)_____ diminish; not because of our innate laziness, but because of our over-concern about our physical appearance. In the old days, most people dreamt of having shelter and a stable food supply. As we no longer struggle for the basic (3)_____, our dreams focus instead on the search for physical beauty, how to obtain and maintain the 'ideal body shape' and healthy life the media promotes. Physical beauty will become the main goal of the majority. They'll do exercises every day, taking (4)_____ to maintain their shape while not noticing that their brains are shrinking. Actually, there is no doubt that they'll work (5)_____ hard to make their brains smaller.

Select the most appropriate option to fill in blank number 5.

(A) so
(B) rarely
(C) impishly
(D) extremely

Answer key

Numerical and Mathematical Ability

Q.5 **(D)** Q.20 **(A)**

Reasoning Ability and Problem Solving

Q.17 **(C)**

General Awareness

Q.1 **(C)**	Q.2 **(D)**	Q.4 **(B)**	Q.5 **(C)**	Q.6 **(C)**	Q.7 **(C)**
Q.9 **(B)**	Q.10 **(A)**	Q.11 **(B)**	Q.12 **(A)**	Q.14 **(C)**	Q.15 **(B)**
Q.16 **(D)**	Q.17 **(D)**	Q.19 **(B)**	Q.20 **(A)**	Q.21 **(A)**	Q.22 **(B)**
Q.23 **(D)**	Q.24 **(D)**				

English Language and Comprehension

Q.1 **(C)**	Q.2 **(D)**	Q.3 **(A)**	Q.4 **(A)**	Q.5 **(D)**	Q.6 **(D)**
Q.7 **(B)**	Q.8 **(B)**	Q.9 **(C)**	Q.10 **(B)**	Q.11 **(C)**	Q.12 **(A)**
Q.13 **(D)**	Q.14 **(C)**	Q.15 **(C)**	Q.16 **(A)**	Q.17 **(B)**	Q.18 **(A)**
Q.19 **(B)**	Q.20 **(D)**	Q.21 **(C)**	Q.22 **(B)**	Q.23 **(A)**	Q.24 **(B)**
Q.25 **(D)**					

Explanations

Numerical and Mathematical Ability

Q.5 · Answer (D) Gain by 11%

The overheads add to the cost: CP = 25,000 + 1,500 = ₹26,500. The gain is 29,500 − 26,500 = ₹3,000, and 3000/26500 × 100 ≈ 11.3%, a gain of 11%.

Q.20 · Answer (A) 63 km/h

The whole 120 km at 72 km/h takes 120/72 = 5/3 h, and the first 60 km took 60/84 = 5/7 h. The next 60 km take 5/3 − 5/7 = 20/21 h, a speed of 60 ÷ 20/21 = 63 km/h.

Reasoning Ability and Problem Solving

Q.17 · Answer (C) J

Number the seats 1 to 7 from the right end of the row (the people face south); W is 3rd. G is two seats to S's left with D and H on either side of it, so S can only be 4th (in 1st or 2nd, G or its neighbour would take W's seat; in 5th or beyond, G would be at the left end or past it, without a seat on each side): G is 6th, with D and H in 5th and 7th. Y third to D's right rules out D in 7th (Y would take S's seat), so D is 5th, H 7th, Y 2nd and J 1st, at the right end.

General Awareness

Q.1 · Answer (C) 2016

The Pradhan Mantri Rojgar Protsahan Yojana of the Ministry of Labour and Employment began in August 2016 to encourage employers to create new jobs: for new employees, the government paid the employer's pension (EPS) contribution, and from April 2018 the employer's whole EPF and EPS contribution.

Q.2 · Answer (D) Pinjar

Amrita Pritam's Partition novel 'Pinjar' (1950) was filmed by Chandraprakash Dwivedi in 2003, and the film won the National Film Award for Best Feature Film on National Integration. 'Raseedi Ticket' is her autobiography.

Q.4 · Answer (B) Indira Gandhi

The Fundamental Duties (Article 51A, Part IVA) were added by the 42nd Amendment, 1976, on the Swaran Singh Committee's recommendation, while Indira Gandhi was Prime Minister.

Q.5 · Answer (C) Prof. Walker

SSC's key gives Walker: economics textbooks usually credit 'Money is what money does', a definition of money by its functions (whatever does the work of money is money), to the American economist Francis A. Walker.

Q.6 · Answer (C) Paradip Port

Paradip, near the mouth of the Mahanadi in Jagatsinghpur district, is Odisha's major port. Haldia is in West Bengal, Kandla (Deendayal) in Gujarat and Tuticorin (V. O. Chidambaranar) in Tamil Nadu.

Q.7 · Answer (C) Kathak

Rohini Bhate, Pandit Munnalal Shukla, Kumudini Lakhia and Uma Sharma are all noted Kathak dancers and gurus.

Q.9 · Answer (B) Sri Lanka

India beat Sri Lanka by six wickets in the 2011 World Cup final at the Wankhede Stadium, Mumbai, on 2 April 2011.

Q.10 · Answer (A) Kerala

Mohiniyattam, the 'dance of the enchantress', is the classical dance of Kerala, traditionally a solo dance performed by women.

Q.11 · Answer (B) Single party system
India has a multi-party system, marked at times by factions, defections and a weak opposition; it has never had a single-party system.

Q.12 · Answer (A) Champaran Satyagraha
Champaran in Bihar (1917), against the forced cultivation of indigo, was Gandhi's first satyagraha in India. Kheda followed in 1918 and the Rowlatt Satyagraha in 1919; the Bardoli Satyagraha of 1928 was led by Vallabhbhai Patel.

Q.14 · Answer (C) Chhau
Chhau, danced in Seraikela (Jharkhand), Purulia (West Bengal) and Mayurbhanj (Odisha), draws on mock combat, the gaits of birds and animals and the chores of village women, and is performed mostly by men.

Q.15 · Answer (B) Delhi
The Red Fort (Lal Qila) in Delhi was built by Shah Jahan between 1639 and 1648 as the palace-fort of his new capital, Shahjahanabad.

Q.16 · Answer (D) Dev Darshan
In November 2022 Chief Minister Pramod Sawant launched the Mukhyamantri Dev Darshan Yatra Yojana, a free state-funded pilgrimage for older residents, flagging off a busload of pilgrims to Tirupati.

Q.17 · Answer (D) 7
In the Vijay Hazare Trophy quarter-final against Uttar Pradesh in November 2022, Ruturaj Gaikwad hit seven sixes in one over from Shiva Singh (one of the balls a no-ball), the first time in List-A cricket, on his way to 220 not out.

Q.19 · Answer (B) The thorn forest and scrubs
NCERT lists camels, with wild asses, foxes and wolves, among the animals of the tropical thorn forests and scrubs of India's dry north-west, such as Rajasthan and Gujarat.

Q.20 · Answer (A) Lord Hastings
The policy of 'paramountcy', under which the Company claimed its authority was greater than that of the Indian states, was initiated under Lord Hastings, Governor-General from 1813 to 1823 (not Warren Hastings).

Q.21 · Answer (A) Jain
Paryushana, a period of fasting, reflection and forgiveness held in the month of Bhadrapada, is the most important annual festival of the Jains.

Q.22 · Answer (B) Robert Hooke
Robert Hooke named the cell in 1665, in 'Micrographia', after seeing the tiny box-like compartments of a thin slice of cork under his microscope.

Q.23 · Answer (D) Financial service to disadvantaged people
Microfinance institutions give small loans and other financial services to poor and low-income people who lack access to ordinary banking.

Q.24 · Answer (D) Odisha
Odisha were the overall champions in both the men's and women's categories at the first Janjatiya Khel Mahotsav, the tribal games held at KIIT, Bhubaneswar, in June 2023.

English Language and Comprehension

Q.1 · Answer (C) before orbiting an astronaut
'Astronaut' begins with a vowel sound and takes 'an': 'before orbiting an astronaut'. 'A chimp' and 'a Mercury capsule' are correct.

Q.2 · Answer (D) he was not going to call them
After the past reporting verb 'said', the reported clause moves back a tense: 'They said that he was not going to call them.'

Q.3 · Answer (A) ardous
The misspelt word is 'ardous'; the correct spelling is 'arduous'.

Q.4 · Answer (A) Take a risk
To 'throw caution to the wind' is to stop worrying about the danger and take a risk.

Q.5 · Answer (D) Dreary
'Tedious' means long and boring: 'dreary'.

Q.6 · Answer (D) Inedible
'Inedible' means not fit to be eaten. 'Inept' means unskilled, 'ineligible' not qualified and 'ineluctable' unavoidable.

Q.7 · Answer (B) he had not
A condition about the past takes 'would have' and the past participle in the main clause: 'If he had paid attention to the announcement, he would not have missed the train.'

Q.8 · Answer (B) Something very easy
'Child's play' is something very easy to do.

Q.9 · Answer (C) itinerary
The correct spelling is 'itinerary', the planned route or schedule of a journey.

Q.10 · Answer (B) To tell a secret
To 'spill the beans' is to tell a secret.

Q.11 · Answer (C) Watch and take care
To 'keep an eye on' someone is to watch over and look after them.

Q.12 · Answer (A) let me know
'Let' takes an object and the bare infinitive: 'let me know'. The other options use 'known' or 'knew'.

Q.13 · Answer (D) play in the dirt
The two verbs after 'loves to' are parallel: 'Helena loves to dig and play in the dirt'.

Q.14 · Answer (C) by enhancing employability
The means is shown by 'by' and a gerund, parallel with 'helping': 'by enhancing employability and labour productivity and helping countries ...'.

Q.15 · Answer (C) likes to watch
'Like' is followed by a to-infinitive (or a gerund), and the singular 'everyone' takes 'likes': 'Everyone likes to watch a magic show.'

Q.16 · Answer (A) He is the best-looking hero in the entire film industry.
Comparing one hero with all the others in the industry needs the superlative: 'the best-looking hero in the entire film industry'.

Q.17 · Answer (B) committed
To be 'committed' to something is to be dedicated to it: first to his job, then to his family.

Q.18 · Answer (A) Feign
To 'pretend' is to 'feign', to make a false show of something.

Q.19 · Answer (B) Disrupt
To 'align' is to put in line or in order; 'disrupt', to throw into disorder, is its opposite. 'Position', 'centre' and 'coincide' are close to it in meaning.

Q.20 · Answer (D) arbitrator
The correct spelling is 'arbitrator', a person chosen to settle a dispute.

Q.21 · Answer (C) tiny

SSC's key gives 'tiny', which contrasts the minority's bodies with their enormous brains and echoes the passage's own 'tiny brains'. 'Minute' (extremely small) is close in meaning but overstates it for a human body; 'minor' describes importance rather than physical size, and 'cute' describes looks.

Q.22 · Answer (B) gradually

The brain will 'gradually' diminish, slowly over time; 'properly' and 'appropriately' make no sense here, and 'slightly' would undercut the passage's 'tiny brains'.

Q.23 · Answer (A) necessities

Shelter and a stable food supply, named just before, are the basic 'necessities' of life, the things people cannot do without; 'amenities' and 'facilities' are comforts and services, not food and shelter.

Q.24 · Answer (B) nutrients

To keep their shape they take 'nutrients', the substances the body needs. 'Nutrition' is nourishment in general, not something one 'takes', and preservatives and additives are put into food.

Q.25 · Answer (D) extremely

'Extremely' intensifies 'hard': they will work very hard at it. 'So hard' is informal unless a 'that' clause follows, and 'rarely' and 'impishly' (mischievously) make no sense with 'hard'.

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